

Aiming for Polaris



Proxy Metric

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Volition - Cognition



Proxy Metric



The mistake of confusing orientation for destination. What begins as a reference becomes an objective; what was meant to point the way becomes the place itself. Optimization proceeds flawlessly toward the wrong thing.



surrogate objective, heuristics, goal misalignment, Goodhart's law, means-end confusion



- ▲ Provides direction and structure in complex spaces.
- ▼ Substitutes the proxy for the goal; success becomes misalignment.
- ▶ Treat the target card as a mere pointer. Ask what it was meant to point toward.



"What am I optimizing simply because it is measurable?"



They aligned their course to the brightest point in the sky. When the ground grew hostile and the path led into open water, they corrected their steps but not their bearing.